From an Approval Letter to a Routine

An ordered plan for your family's part of keeping up with Mom's Medicaid, with a line for who does each and by when.

The goal: keeping up with Mom's Medicaid becomes a routine your family shares, with a folder, a calendar, a name beside each job and a written list of questions, instead of something one person carries around in their head.

This is your family's part only. The order is simply the one that makes each action easier, and the “by when” column is yours to fill in. Where a letter from the Medicaid agency gives a date, go by the letter. Share the list, put a name and a day next to each action, and tick it when it's done.

ACTION	WHO	BY WHEN	DONE
1. Read the approval notice all the way through, and put every page in one folder.			
2. Copy down the dates the notice gives, in its own words, including the effective date. Mark anything you don't understand.			
3. Add every later letter from the Medicaid agency to the folder in date order. For each, note what it asks for and any date it gives.			
4. Put the dates from the letters on one calendar, with reminders. If no letter gives a renewal date, write “renewal date not found”.			
5. Start a place for Mom's bank and other account statements as they arrive, and for a copy of anything the family sends to the agency.			
6. Write down what has changed since the application: income, accounts and property, where Mom lives, her care setting, her marital status. What changed and when, nothing more.			
7. Write down any money that has arrived or is expected outside her usual income, such as an inheritance, a gift, or proceeds from a sale or an insurance policy.			
8. Agree who opens the mail, who keeps the folder and the calendar, and who makes the calls. Put the names in the front of the folder.			
9. List your questions, and beside each write who it goes to: the Medicaid agency, your Medicaid planner, an elder law attorney, or “not sure”.			

ACTION	WHO	BY WHEN	DONE
10. Pick a regular time to go through the folder together: new letters, dates coming up, anything that has changed.			

You're done when

The letters are in one folder, the dates you know are on a calendar, what has changed is written down, each job has a name beside it, and your questions are on paper with who each one goes to. That is a routine under way. What the notices require, which changes need to be reported, and anything about what to do with Mom's money or property aren't on this list, because those aren't the family's to settle alone.

If you get stuck

- Don't fill a gap by guessing. “We don't know yet” is a finished line.
- If a letter asks for something or gives a date, the letter comes before this plan. Call the number on it with any question about what it is asking for.
- If something significant changes, or money arrives that nobody expected, write it down and ask your Medicaid planner about it before anyone acts on it.

What this plan doesn't do

It organizes your family's part. It doesn't say what Mom's Medicaid requires, decide whether a change has to be reported, or determine or guarantee her eligibility. Renewal, reporting and recordkeeping requirements vary by state and by case, so follow the Medicaid agency's own notices. Nothing here is legal, financial or tax advice.

Ready for the next step?

You've turned an approval letter into the start of a routine. The planning interview asks about your family's situation and gives you a free planning report you can bring to any conversation about paying for Mom's care.

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